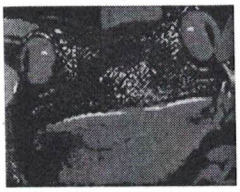
Tibetan Treefrog Publishing©

Evolution of Manford



ISSN 1544-1423

By Brian Weilert

Bill: Bill Manford here. Still as rock-hard at 88 as I was at 18.

Mira: If the rock you're referring to has the consistency of boiled squash, then you are indeed correct.

Bill: *(pointing to wife)* The forked-tongued seahag behind me is my loving wife of 70 years, Mira.

Mira: Has it just been 70? Seems longer.

Bill: Nope, just 70. I know because I mark every year down in my special little book.

Mira: *(sincere)* Really? How sweet.

Bill: Yep, I call it my "years of burden" book. I figure if I get to 80, God's got to let me in to heaven. I bet Job himself didn't accumulate more than 20 marks. I'm a shoe-in.

Mira: I have a thought as to what to put my shoe in.

Bill: Careful Mira, it is our anniversary and after slaving in front of a hot microwave all day to prepare a special dinner I would hate to see you *(yelling)* DIE OF HEART FAILURE!!!

Mira: Nice try. But you know I didn't spend a minute by the microwave but by the blender you toothless coot.

Bill: I thought I smelled your famous, blue-ribbon, pureed meatloaf.

(they sit down to eat)

Mira: Would you like some salad?

Bill: Can't, gives me heart burn.

Mira: Salad gives you heart burn? Since when?

Bill: Since always.

Mira: You've had a salad every supper for every year I've known you.

Bill: And I've always suffered in silence. *(patting stomach)* Tough as nails.

Mira: You haven't been silent your whole life and as for *tough as nails*, only if you believe that you recovered from all the fatal ailments you've claimed to have suffered from the past seven decades. I have a little special book too. I call it my "what is Bill dieing from now" book. My favorite is your 1952 bout with bubonic plague.

Bill: Quit your snickering woman, I had all the symptoms. Still think I just licked it. One good thing from years of eating your vile swill is my immune system is well developed.

Mira: *(looking below his waist)* Good to hear something on that prune you call a body is developed.

Bill: *(beaten)* Pass the salad.

Mira: My hero.

(slight pause)

Bill: What happened to us?

Mira: What do you mean?

Bill: I don't remember us being this way.

Mira: I remember the first meal we shared together.

Bill: Yep, 3rd grade, I knew at that moment I would need to take care of you for the rest of my life. Snatched you right out of the grips of despair I did.

(Move from table to sit on ground. They are now 3rd graders; 1924)

Mira: Hey.

Bill: *(very shy)* Hey.

Mira: What's your name?

Bill: Billy. What's yours?

Mira: Mira Colleen McGillicutty. What ya got there wrapped in that ol' dirty rag?

Bill: Nothin' much. Sandwich and some carrots.

Mira: Don't see no meat on that sandwich?

Bill: That's cause it's my favorite, mashed potatoes.

Mira: Oh, *(pause)* you got any dessert?

Bill: I said I had carrots.

Mira: No silly, like good stuff? Let's see what mom packed me in my pail. *(looks in pail and starts taking inventory)* Turkey sandwich, fresh butter and crackers….Ah, here we are, two homemade chocolate chip cookies. Want one?

Bill: Really?

Mira: Yeah, sure. Why not? You can even have the big one.

Bill: Thanks

Mira: Hey, what happened to your eye?

Bill: Nothin'

Mira: How come it's all purple and stuff?

Bill: You ask a lot of questions.

Mira: Yeah?

Bill: Yeah!

Mira: It's awful cold. How come you don't got a coat?

Bill: *(getting angry)* I ain't cold.

Mira: Even your toes don't get cold in the snow sticken' out of your shoes like that?

Bill: *(silence, a cold stare)*

Mira: I'm sorry, just stupid sometimes. Still want the cookie?

Bill: Naw, sugar makes me sick. That's why I don't pack any sweets.

Mira: Don't your mommy pack your lunch?

Bill: My mom's in heaven.

Mira: What about your daddy?

Bill: *(silence)*

Mira: What, ain't you got a daddy either?

Bill: *(he reaches up at touches his eye)*

Mira: *(realizing what he is saying)* Oh, sorry.

Bill: *(stands)* Lunch is about over, I got to be goin'

Mira: It just started, plus you ain't even ate your lunch yet.

Bill: Trying to lose a little weight.

Mira: *(laughing)* Billy, your as skinny as that willow switch.

Bill: Bye Mira, *(starts to leave and turns back)* Say, can I have that cookie?

Mira: Thought it would make you all sick and stuff?

Bill: Yeah, but I'm tough as nails. *(smiles)*

Mira: *(gives him the cookie)*

Bill: *(sits back at table, old again)* You know, after 500 years of marriage…

Mira: *(now standing)* 70 years

Bill: I was going for how it felt, not actual number of years. After 500 years of marriage, I still enjoy eating meals with you.

Mira: Really? Then why so mean all the time?

Bill: Love.

Mira: Love?

Bill: Yep, no way I would talk to someone I didn't love the way I talk with you. Besides you give as good as you take.

Mira: We have had some interesting meals over the years.

Bill: Like your last year of school. I remember it like it was yesterday.

Mira: Which for you is something, because you usually can't remember yesterday.

Bill: I thought we were going to play nice?

Mira: Sorry, saw an opening.

Bill: You were beautiful, glowing, in fact.

Mira: And you were covered in filth.

Bill: Not my fault I had to work for a living. Hell, after dad left me in '29 when the market crashed I had to quit school and fend for myself. Not many fourteen year old boys had to make it on their own, even back then. Wasn't till Roosevelt's "New Deal" that I even landed a decent job in '33.

Mira: *(drifts forward, rubbing stomach; 1933)* You were so strong and handsome. You were so proud that day telling my about you new job with the highway department. And I went and ruined it.

Bill: *(running up to her, very excited)* Honey! You ain't goin to believe this. I just landed a great job with the state highway department. Drop that ol' sandwich, I'm going take you some place really nice! From now on you an I are going to have all sorts of fun.

Mira: Oh, Billy, that's great. I'm so proud of you. You work so hard. *(eyes drift off)*

Bill: What's wrong. I do something wrong?

Mira: Billy, I have news too. *(pause)* I'm going to have a baby.

Bill: Oh, um…

Mira: Oh, Billy I'm so sorry.

Bill: *(takes a moment)* Sorry? Sorry? What for. I was going to marry you anyways. We'll just do it sooner, that's all. *(rubs her stomach)* Bet that boy of ours will be tough as nails.

Mira: Boy?

Bill: Sure a boy, what else?

Mira: I love you. *(hugs and kisses him)*

(Bill breaks free and walks back to table obviously disturbed)

Bill: *(old again)* Anything for dessert? Or did you just figure I wasn't worth it.

Mira: What's wrong with you all of a sudden?

Bill: I'll tell you what's wrong…What's wrong is…..I miss my boy.

Mira: Oh, Bill, I'm sorry, that's a meal I would love to forget too. *(drifts forward 1951)*

Bill, dinner will be ready in a minute. Honey, the paper and mail is on the corner table if you want to read it before we eat.

Bill: *(looks as if going through mail, opens up a letter, and with a shocked face walks toward his wife)* Mira?

Mira: *(knows something is wrong)* What is it Bill? *(frantic)* What is it?!

Bill: It's from the defense department. Our boy…*(crying)* Oh my God, my boy is dead.

Mira: *(loosing it, hitting Bill)* You bastard! You bastard! I told you to not let him join the Army. I told you he would die in Korea.

Bill: *(shocked at the outburst)* I didn't, I ….

Mira: *(screaming)* You had to tell him a real man would join, you forced him to go. Said he had to be tough. Just because you had to make it on your own you forced your own boy out when he wasn't ready. And now he's dead. *(shaking him)* YOU KILLED HIM!!!!

Bill: *(again breaking free back to the table, old again)* I miss him a lot.

Mira: *(joins him, in tears but calm)* I miss him too. (pause) Bill?

Bill: Yes?

Mira: I was wrong you know. All those years ago, I was wrong. It wasn't your fault. It could have happened here at home. It was his time that's all. God wanted him.

Bill: Thank you for saying it, but it don't change the fact that there is some truth to what you said that night. I so badly wanted him to be a strong man, to be independent that I never even thought....

Mira: I know, I know. I forgave you many many years ago, I think you could do the same. *(pause)* How's the salad?

Bill: Disgusting, as usual.

Mira: That's my Bill. *(pause)* Hey, you want to know my most memorable meal with you?

Bill: No, but I'm sure you're going tell me anyway.

Mira: *(Mira moves forward; 1975)* The banquet the fire department gave in your honor for saving that little girl.

Bill: Yeah, I done forgot about that night. *(moves forward)*

Mira: Quit fidgeting, you look nice.

Bill: It's this damn tie, choking me to death.

Mira: *(slapping his hands as he pulls at collar)* Would you stop it, you look sooo handsome.

Bill: I don't know what the fuss is all about. Didn't do anything any other man wouldn't have done in my shoes.

Mira: Bill, I don't know many 60 year old men that would but even less that could do what you did. You were so brave. *(kisses him)*

Bill: Would you stop it, people are looking.

Mira: Wait till I get my brave hero home, then they could really get a show. *(rubbing his body)*

Bill: Stop it, you're embarrassing yourself. People will done think I stopped on 4th street and picked up a geriatric prostitute.

Mira: *(pouting)* You're no fun.

Bill: Finally, my secrets out.

Mira: Well, I proud of you anyway. Isn't this food wonderful?

Bill: Put some of those rolls in your purse.

Mira: I will not! Besides they aren't nearly as good as mine.

Bill: For killing squirrels maybe. Hey, hush up they're talking about me.

(pause while they listen to him being announced)

Mira: *(clapping)* Well go on up, and leave that tie alone.

Bill: *(moves forward as if at microphone)* Thank you for your kind words. I'm not much of a talker *(Mira rolls eyes)* so please excuse me as I bumble through this. Sometimes, God puts us in a spot to do his work. Maybe, puts us there to allow us to make amends for past sins. *(looks at wife)* I'm nothin' special. Never have been. When I went into that building I never even thought about being no hero, I just thought about doing what's right. About being the man I always said I was, and expected others around me to be. Maybe I push too hard sometimes, *(starts to cry)* Maybe there's forgiveness in giving a life back. It was a miracle. The fact that this old coot was able to save that little girl…well maybe, in way we saved each other. (*wipes tears)* I'm sorry, I'm just rambling on like some senile ol' fart. I'm sorry. Thank you. *(steps back to Mira)*

Mira: *(clapping)* Oh, Bill Manford you're a fine fine man. Your boy would be so proud of you.

Bill: Sorry, if I embarrassed you. *(Drifts back, old again)*

Mira: *(drift back, old again)* It was your finest hour. I wouldn't have wanted to be married to any other man that night. Still don't.

Bill: *(turns and hugs his wife, kissing her forehead)* You know Mira Colleen McGillicutty, that I love you more than anything in this world, don't you?

Mira: I do.

Bill: And you know that I loved you the first day I saw you in 3rd grade.

Mira: I do.

Bill: And that….

Mira: I do.

Bill: *(breaking free)* Is there anything you don't know you know-it-all ol' bitty?! Here I am being all sentimental and all you can say is, "I do".

Mira: I know one more thing.

Bill: And just what is that Miss I'm too smart for the rest of the world?

Mira: I know I have a batch of chocolate chips cookies ready to come out of the oven. You want one?

Bill: Really, seahag?

Mira: Yep, and you can even have the big one. You ol' coot.

Both: Happy anniversary.

Tibetan Treefrog Publishing
111 N Eddy
Fort Scott, KS 66701
Copyright 2003